The Abdalla Family Tree

Oct 7, 2026 · @Mo

Summary

Your mother's family are **Ja'aliyin of Metemma**, the old Ja'ali town on the west bank of the Nile opposite Shendi. Everything below about the family itself is family memory. No written source found so far names any of these people.

- **Your grandfather's male line:** Abbas son of Abdalla son of Osman son of Isa son of Mohamed son of Hamed (or possibly Ahmed). Abbas worked with livestock and was known as **Hadarbi**.
- **Your grandfather's mother:** Ajeba, of the house called "Gnagn". She was the daughter of Sitt al-Jil ("lady of her generation"), daughter of **Idris of the Buglab**. The Buglab are a Ja'ali family who lived in Metemma.
- **Your grandmother:** Shafa, daughter of Abdalla son of Mohamed son of Ahmed son of Amara. Her mother was a daughter of Mohamed Idris, Sitt al-Jil's brother.
- Abbas and Shafa were therefore **second cousins**. Both were great-grandchildren of Idris of the Buglab.
- Your mother married Kamal Satti. They met at the University of Khartoum. This side of the family has no known link to Dongola.

What the research added:

- No published genealogy lists a Buglab house among the Ja'aliyin, so your family's knowledge is the only record of it. Two places have similar names, al-Buqlab in the 'Aliyab area and El Bqedab in Metemma locality, but nothing ties them to the family.
- "Hadarbi" is written حدربي in Arabic and is carried by many unrelated families. The likeliest Ja'ali meaning is the Hadarba branch of the Mukabirab. Another is the Hadarba merchants from Suakin, who traded at Shendi and Metemma in the 1800s.
- By rough estimate, Isa or Osman would have been an adult when the Mahdist army sacked Metemma in 1897.

Deep roots: the Ja'aliyin of Metemma

The Ja'aliyin trace their descent to Ibrahim Ja'al and, by tradition, to al-'Abbas, the Prophet's uncle. Their genealogies run from Ibrahim Ja'al through Ghanim, Dawwab and 'Arman to King 'Adlan. 'Adlan's sons are the ancestors of the main houses around Metemma (tradition, from MacMichael's manuscripts and 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim):

House	Ancestor	Where	Notes
Nifiʻab	Nafiʻa son of ʻAdlan	Metemma and Sayal Karim al-Din, west bank	Their Al Farah family ruled Metemma after 1821, down to ʻAbdallah wad Saʻd, killed in 1897
Saʻadab	Saʻd Abu Dabus, a descendant of ʻAdlan in most versions	Shendi and Metemma	Mek Musaʻad ruled from Metemma from about 1794 to 1822, after Mek Nimr took Shendi in 1801
Nafaʻab	Nafaʻa son of ʻAdlan	East bank, the Shendi side	Many later moved south to the Gezira
ʻAliab	ʻAli son of ʻAbd al-Daim son of ʻAdlan	North towards Ed-Damer	Two other sons of ʻAbd al-Daim, both named Hammad, have descendants in Metemma
Mukabirab (Kabirab)	Mukabir son of ʻArman	Saqadi near Metemma; al-Damer; Omdurman	Includes a branch called the **Hadarba**

Which house your family belongs to is not known. The Buglab and the name Hadarbi are the two clues.

What "Hadarbi" may mean. In Arabic it is written حدربي, the singular of Hadarba (حدارية). Many unrelated Sudanese families carry it, so it does not identify a lineage by itself. Six meanings are possible:

Meaning	Where	How well it fits
The Hadarba branch of the Jaʻali Mukabirab	Saqadi near Metemma; Omdurman	Best Jaʻali fit; no names match yet
The Hadarba merchants from Suakin	Traded at Shendi in 1814 and were "still to be seen" at Metemma and Shendi decades later	Fits a family in the animal trade; a Jaʻali family could gain the name by marriage or trade (my inference)
The Hudur trading houses of Metemma (Qandurab, Shabburab, Al al-Birr)	Metemma and Shendi	Weaker: their singular is Hadari (حضري), not Hadarbi

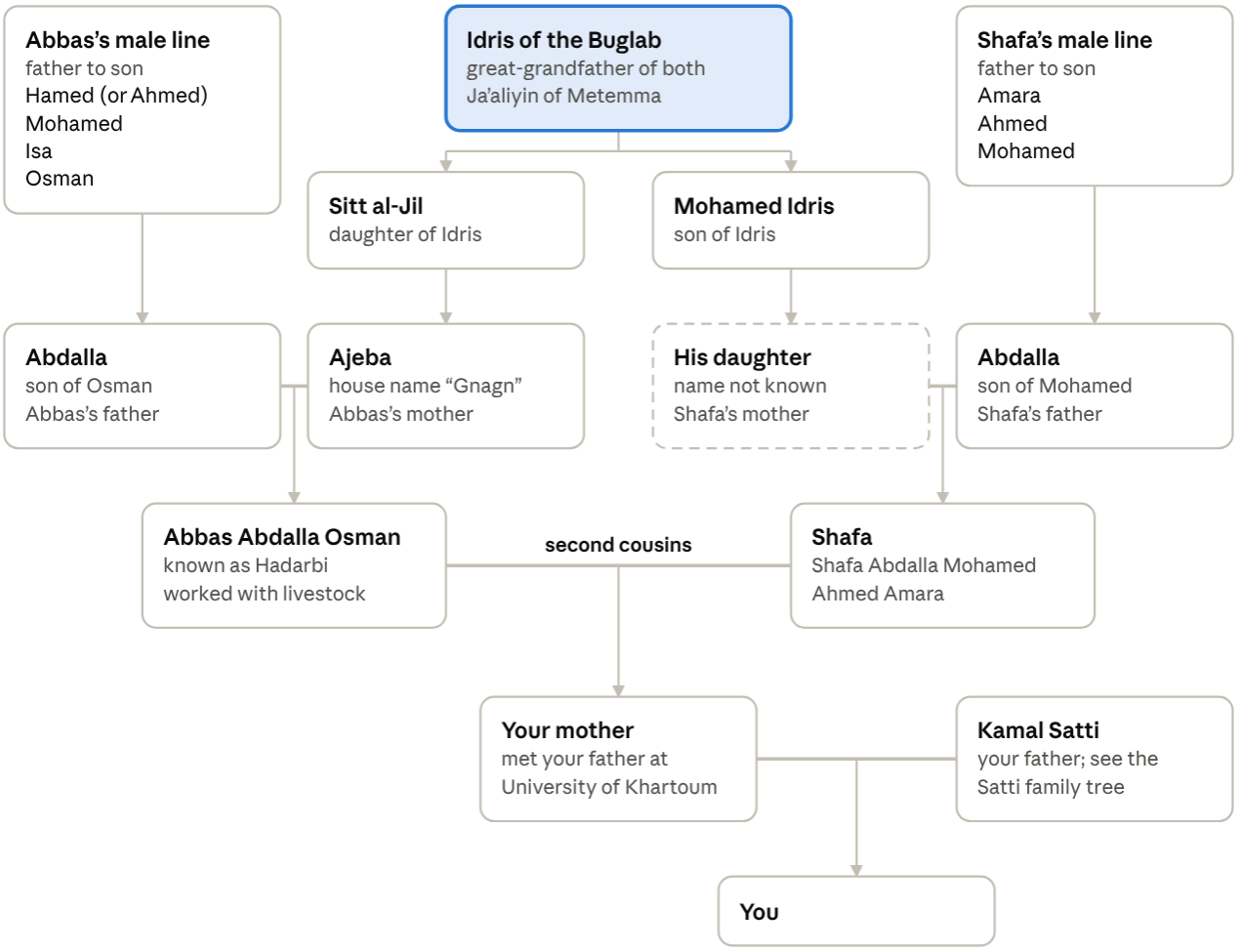
Meaning	Where	How well it fits
A "Hadrab" section under Nafa'a	East bank	Weak: found in one manuscript that MacMichael distrusted
The Hadarbiyun of the Ja'ali Kurtan	White Nile and Kordofan	Weak: no Metemma link
A general name for traders of Arabian origin	Across Sudan	Possible: a 1959 study says the name was used this way

The Hadarba trading world. In 1814 the Swiss traveller Burckhardt called the Hadarba merchants of Suakin "the most substantial of all the traders" at Shendi. They brought Indian cloth and spices, and took gold and slaves in return. Shendi's market then drew "several thousands of people" on market days, most of whom brought cattle for sale.

The full tree

Your grandparents Abbas and Shafa both descend from Idris of the Buglab

All from family memory. Arrows run from parent to child; short level lines join a married couple.



Your mother's family · two lines that meet at Idris of the Buglab

Both of your mother's parents descend from **Idris of the Buglab**: Abbas through his mother Ajeba, and Shafa through her mother. Anyone else descended from Idris is your relative on both sides.

Person	Relation to you	Born (my estimate)	What is known
Hamed (or Ahmed)	5× great-grandfather	about 1770–1800	Most probably Hamed
Mohamed son of Hamed	4× great-grandfather	about 1795–1835	
Isa son of Mohamed	3× great-grandfather	about 1820–70	The name is Isa, not 'Isawi

Person	Relation to you	Born (my estimate)	What is known
Osman son of Isa	2× great-grandfather	about 1845–1900	
Abdalla son of Osman	Great-grandfather	about 1870–1920	Married Ajeba
Ajeba	Great-grandmother		Of the house called "Gnagn"; daughter of Sitt al-Jil
Sitt al-Jil daughter of Idris	2× great-grandmother		Her name means "lady of her generation"
Idris of the Buglab	3× great-grandfather, twice over		Ja'ali; the Buglab lived in Metemma
Mohamed Idris	2× great-grandfather		Sitt al-Jil's brother
Daughter of Mohamed Idris	Great-grandmother		Name not known; Shafa's mother
Amara, then Ahmed, then Mohamed	4×, 3× and 2× great-grandfathers		Shafa's male line
Abdalla son of Mohamed	Great-grandfather		Shafa's father
Abbas Abdalla Osman	Grandfather		Known as Hadarbi; worked with livestock
Shafa Abdalla Mohamed Ahmed Amara	Grandmother		Abbas's second cousin
Your mother			Met your father, Kamal Satti, at the University of Khartoum

Cousins. No brothers, sisters or cousins of Abbas or Shafa appear in any record, and no one has given their names yet. The quickest way to widen this tree is to list the other children and grandchildren of Sitt al-Jil and of Mohamed Idris, and your mother's own brothers and sisters.

Where the family lived, and what each generation lived through

Metemma lies on the west bank of the Nile, opposite Shendi and north of Khartoum. The family remembers Metemma and the Ja'aliyin, and never mentioned Dongola. Your parents met at the University of Khartoum. Whether the family lived in Omdurman along the way is not confirmed.

The right-hand column uses my rough birth estimates, so treat it as a guide only.

Years	What happened at Metemma	Who in the family was probably alive
About 1794–1822	Mek Musa'ad of the Sa'adab ruled from Metemma. Mek Nimr held Shendi, across the river, from 1801	Hamed
1822–23	Mek Nimr burned the Egyptian commander Isma'il Pasha to death at Shendi. In revenge the Defterdar's army destroyed Shendi and Metemma	Hamed, and Mohamed as a child
1821–85	Turco-Egyptian rule. The Al Farah family of the Nifi'ab governed Metemma	Mohamed, Isa
January 1885	Battle of Abu Tulayh (Abu Klea), near Metemma, as a British column tried to reach Khartoum	Isa, Osman
1 July 1897	The Mahdist commander Mahmud wad Ahmad sacked Metemma, and its chief 'Abdallah wad Sa'd was killed. The historian Shuqayr counts about 2,000 men killed and 23,056 Ja'aliyin taken to Omdurman; later historians think his figures may be too high	Osman, and perhaps Abdalla as a child
From 1898	Anglo-Egyptian rule. Most Ja'aliyin farmed and herded; many others became small traders and town workers	Abdalla
1900s	Abbas worked with livestock	Abbas and Shafa
Later 1900s	Your mother met Kamal Satti at the University of Khartoum	Your mother

Why 1897 matters. The forced move of thousands of Ja'aliyin from Metemma to Omdurman is a documented way that a Metemma family could have ended up near the capital. Nothing yet ties your family to it. Asking whether the family has stories about "the Kitla" (the killing) of Metemma could settle it.

Related families and possible relatives

The first three rows are your family as you described it. The rest are groups found in the records that share a name or a place with the family. None of them is shown to be related.

Family or group	Link to you	Where	Status
The Buglab: Idris, his daughter Sitt al-Jil and his son Mohamed Idris	The house of your 3× great-grandfather, on both grandparents' sides	Metemma	Family memory; no published record
The house called **"Gnagn"**	Ajeba's house name	Not stated	Family memory
Amara's line: Amara, Ahmed, Mohamed, Abdalla, then Shafa	Your grandmother's male line	Not stated	Family memory
The Hadarba of the Mukabirab, including Awlad Hammad son of Sulayman	Possible distant kin, if "Hadarbi" means this house	Omdurman; Saqadi near Metemma	Lead
The Hudur trading houses: Qandurab, Shabburab, Al al-Birr	Possible neighbours or in-laws in Metemma	Metemma and Shendi	Weak lead
The al-Hadarbi family of Wad Nubawi, descendants of Hasan Hadarbi	Same surname, but of eastern Hadarba origin	Omdurman	Probably unrelated
The people of al-Buqlab, a hamlet in the 'Aliyab	A similar name in a Ja'ali farming area	Ed-Damer locality, east bank	Weak lead: your family places the Buglab in Metemma
El Bqedab	A place with a similar sound	Metemma locality	Weak lead

The Ja′ali houses of Metemma (Nifi′ab, Sa′adab and others; see *Deep roots*) are your mother′s people in the wider sense. Which one the Buglab or Abbas′s line belongs to is not known.

What the DNA says

Your father and your sibling tested with 23andMe. Your mother has not, but her mix can be estimated, because a child′s mix is close to the average of both parents.

	Your father	Your sibling	Your mother (estimate)
Sub-Saharan African	47.9%	58.8%	about 65–72%
East African (within that)	44.8%	51.3%	about 58%
West African (within that)	1.4%	4.8%	about 8%
Middle Eastern & North African	48.2%	38.3%	about 25–32%

Your mother′s maternal line: L3f1b. This is your sibling′s result, and yours too: the mother-to-mother line through your mother, Shafa and Shafa′s mother.

- It is an African line with an East African root, about 11,000–16,000 years old, which spread west across the Sahel (documented).
- It is uncommon on the Sudanese Nile: about 3% in a Khartoum sample, and none of 66 people at the medieval Nubian cemetery of Kulubnarti. It is commoner to the west: about 12% in Chad Baggara Arabs and 14% in one Lake Chad group (an unpublished thesis), and 5–7% in Nigeria.
- It is still an ordinary Sudanese line. It cannot identify a tribe or a town, or say when it reached Metemma.

What stands out.

- Your mother′s side appears more Sub-Saharan than your father′s, although the Ja′aliyin identify as Arab. Overall the Ja′aliyin and Danagla are genetically very similar (Hollfelder et al. 2017), so the difference reflects these particular families (inference).
- Studies find almost no West African DNA in riverine Sudanese. Your mother′s estimated 8%, together with her L3f1b line, may point to an ancestor from the western Sahel, such as the Hausa or Fulani communities settled in Sudan. Metemma and Shendi were major caravan and market towns. This is an inference: small percentages are noisy, and the timing is unknown.

- Your grandparents' second-cousin marriage does not change these numbers. It gives your mother some stretches of identical DNA, and it can make relatives on her side look closer than they are in DNA match lists.
- A test of your mother would replace these estimates with real numbers.

Sources: Hollfelder et al. 2017, *PLoS Genetics*; Sirak et al. 2021, *Nature Communications*; Fähnrich et al. 2023, *Journal of Advanced Research*; Soares et al. 2012, *Molecular Biology and Evolution*; Černý et al. 2009, *BMC Evolutionary Biology*; Tlačbabová 2017, Charles University thesis; 23andMe Ancestry Composition Guide (2025).

Work, ambitions and character

No source records the work, words or character of any named ancestor on your mother's side. Abbas's livestock work is family memory. The community they lived in is well recorded: the Ja'aliyin of Metemma and Shendi farmed the riverbank, herded animals and traded at one of the region's biggest livestock markets.

Era	Who	What the record shows	Status
1814	People of the Shendi–Metemma reach	Burckhardt saw "several thousands of people" on market days, "the greater part of whom bring cattle for sale": 400–500 camels, as many cows, a hundred donkeys and 20–30 horses	Documented
1814	Hadarba merchants from Suakin	"The most substantial of all the traders" at Shendi, trading Indian cloth and spices	Documented (group only)
About 1860	Hadariba trading network	The historian Bjørkelo lists a branch "at al-Matamma". He also notes that Qallabat was sometimes called al-Matamma, so this may not be the Nile town	Lead
1880s–1897	Ja'aliyin of Metemma	War losses, the 1889 famine, then the 1897 sack of Metemma, in which over 2,000 died	Documented

Era	Who	What the record shows	Status
About 1920	Ja'aliyin between Shabluka and the Atbara	MacMichael: "the nucleus of the tribe remain cultivators and herdsmen", sending their flocks east with kin; many others were "small traders and colonists and employees"	Documented
1900s	Abbas	Worked with livestock; whether as trader, herder or drover is not recorded	Family memory
Later 1900s	Your mother's generation	Your parents met at the University of Khartoum, part of the wider move from Nile villages to the capital	Family memory

What they aimed for. Nothing is recorded in anyone's own words. The family's choices show a pattern: work with animals, marriage inside the kin group (Abbas married Shafa, a fellow descendant of Idris of the Buglab), and, in your mother's generation, the University of Khartoum.

Character. Nothing describes how Abbas, Shafa or any named ancestor behaved. Two things from their town's history are worth knowing, as context only:

- In 1897 Metemma's chief, 'Abdallah wad Sa'd, refused to quarter the Khalifa's army, arguing it would renew "the old shame that befell the Ja'aliyin". He held the town with about 2,500 men and only 80 working rifles, and died defending it.
- Travellers' opinions about whole peoples are not evidence about your family. Burckhardt in 1814, for example, said the Ja'aliyin "boast of their sincerity to those to whom they have pledged their word".

How the family's world changed. In 1814 the local Ja'aliyin were more nomadic than settled. By 1920 most were settled farmers who sent their flocks east with herding kin. The 1897 disaster scattered many into trade and town jobs, and the 20th century drew families like yours to Khartoum.

Sources: Burckhardt, *Travels in Nubia* (1819); MacMichael, *A History of the Arabs in the Sudan*, vol. 1; Medameek on the 1897 Metemma killing.

Evidence: what is documented, what is family memory

Documented means a written source says it. **Family memory** means only your family has said it. **Lead** means a possible match that is not proven.

Claim	Status	Source
Abbas son of Abdalla son of Osman son of Isa son of Mohamed son of Hamed, Ja'aliyin of Metemma	Family memory	Your family
Abdalla married Ajeba (house "Gnagn"), daughter of Sitt al-Jil, daughter of Idris of the Buglab	Family memory	Your family
Shafa was the daughter of Abdalla son of Mohamed son of Ahmed son of Amara, and of a daughter of Mohamed Idris	Family memory	Your family
The Buglab are a Ja'ali family who lived in Metemma	Family memory	Your family; no published genealogy lists them
No published source names any man in Abbas's chain	Documented (a negative result)	Checked: all six volumes of 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim, MacMichael, Burckhardt, Hamadallah, the 1947 Ja'aliyin field notes and others
"Hadarbi" is written حدربي, the singular of Hadarba	Documented	'Awn al-Sharif Qasim
The Ja'ali Mukabirab have a Hadarba branch, including Awlad Hammad son of Sulayman in Omdurman	Documented	'Awn, vols 2 and 6, citing Hamadallah's *Sahm al-Arham*
Mukabirab live at Saqadi, a village listed among Metemma's	Documented (that Saqadi is in Metemma locality is inferred)	'Awn, vol. 3; Arabic Wikipedia, Metemma
Hadarba merchants from Suakin were "the most substantial of all the traders" at Shendi in 1814	Documented	Burckhardt, *Travels in Nubia*

Claim	Status	Source
By 1959 "Hadarba" was used for any trader of Arabian origin	Documented	A. Paul, *Sudan Notes and Records* 40
A hamlet called al-Buqlab (البوقلاب) lies in the 'Aliyab, Ed-Damer locality	Documented; any link to the Buglab is a weak lead	Aliyab scheme; GeoNames
Mek Musa'ad ruled from Metemma about 1794–1822; the Nifi'ab Al Farah ruled after 1821	Documented	MacMichael vol. 1
Metemma was sacked on 1 July 1897, and thousands of Ja'aliyin were taken to Omdurman	Documented; the figures are disputed	Medameek; MacMichael
The family lived in Omdurman	Not confirmed	

Open leads and the questions that would close them

On this side the family is the main source. No archive has yet named anyone in the line.

Questions for your mother and her relatives

1. Which Ja'ali house do Abbas's people and the Buglab belong to: Nifi'ab, Sa'adab, Mukabirab (Kabirab), or another? Which village or quarter of Metemma were they from?
2. What does "Hadarbi" mean to the family? Is it Abbas's own nickname, his father's, or a family name? How is it written?
3. How is Buglab written in Arabic, and who was Idris's father? Is "Gnagn" a nickname, a house or a place?
4. What were the names of Shafa's mother (Mohamed Idris's daughter) and of Ajeba's father?
5. Who are Abbas and Shafa's other children, and the other children and grandchildren of Sitt al-Jil and of Mohamed Idris? These are your living cousins on both sides.
6. Where did Abbas trade or herd livestock, and when did the family move to Khartoum? Does anyone remember stories about the 1897 killing at Metemma?

7. Are there papers: national ID or nationality certificates, marriage contracts, grave locations?

Printed sources still to find

- Uthman Hamad Allah, *Sahm al-Arham wa-al-Silat al-Rahimiya* (pages 9–10, 15, 20 and 171), the source 'Awn used for the Hadarba of the Mukabirab. His unpublished genealogy manuscript may be with his family.
- The unpublished gazetteer of the villages and quarters of Shendi and Metemma made at Shendi University in 2017. It may list a Buglab quarter.
- 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim, *Min Suwar al-Tamazuj al-Qawmi fi al-Sudan* (1990), pages 27–29.

Sources

Genealogies of the Ja'aliyin

- 'Awn al-Sharif Qasim, *Mawsu'at al-Qaba'il wa-al-Ansab fi al-Sudan*, vols 1–6
- H. A. MacMichael, *A History of the Arabs in the Sudan* (1922): vol. 1, vol. 2
- Ma'ruf and Nimr, *al-Ja'aliyun: Tarikhuhum wa-Nasabuhum* (1947 field notes)
- Abdallah Muhammad al-Khabir, *Jami' Nasab al-Ja'aliyin*
- Uthman Hamad Allah, *al-Ta'aruf wa-al-'Ashira*

Metemma and its history

- J. L. Burckhardt, *Travels in Nubia* (1819)
- A. Bjørkelo, *Prelude to the Mahdiyya*; Sudanile translation on the Ja'ali kingdom of Shendi
- Medameek: Abdallah Ali Ibrahim on the 1897 killing at Metemma; Kush News
- Arabic Wikipedia: Metemma; Arabic Wikipedia: 'Abdallah wad Sa'd; almatma blog
- Assayha: the Shendi and Metemma gazetteer project

Hadarbi and Buglab

- A. Paul, "The Hadareb", *Sudan Notes and Records* 40 (1959)
- Arabic Wikipedia: al-Hadarba
- Aliyab Agricultural Scheme: cooperatives; GeoNames: Buqlab